

Korah Business Manager

Problem, Solution, Target, ICP & MVP

Synthesis of decisions and research completed so far

1. Executive summary

Korah's current product direction is a simple Business Manager for small physical businesses in Cameroon. The product is not being defined as an accounting application or a stock application alone. Its central purpose is **daily business control**: helping an owner know what happened in the business, whether money and stock movements are properly recorded, and whether actual cash/stock matches what should be there.

2. The problem we identified

The problem originated from a real situation observed in a cyber/secretarial office. Two connected difficulties were identified:

- Money movements were not consistently recorded during the day. Income could be received without a reliable record of the reason, and money could be taken/given out without being documented.
- When movements were written in notebooks, the records were sometimes difficult to retrieve later, especially at the end of the month.
- At month-end, missing money could therefore be difficult or impossible to explain because there was no complete daily trail.
- Physical products such as juice could be sold without being recorded systematically. The shortage was sometimes discovered only when the product was finished.
- Because sales were not captured, it was impossible to know precisely what had been sold, when it had been sold, or how the missing money related to the stock.
- The consequence was financial leakage, unexplained discrepancies, poor visibility and late discovery of stock shortages.

Core problem statement: Small businesses with frequent daily transactions often lack a simple and reliable way to continuously capture money and stock movements, making it difficult to detect losses, shortages, unexplained expenses and discrepancies before they accumulate.

3. What the problem is NOT

- It is not simply an Excel problem.
- It is not simply an accounting problem.
- It is not simply an inventory problem.

- It is not enough to give employees another place to enter data if the workflow is too slow or complicated.

The deeper issue is that real business activity happens every day, but it is not always captured in a reliable, easy-to-retrieve digital trace.

4. The solution direction

We decided to build a Business Manager rather than a narrow accounting or stock-control application.

Core product thesis:

“A daily business control system for small businesses.”

The system should make recording business events simple and use those events to automatically update the relevant money, sales, stock and activity information.

A sale should therefore be treated as a business event, not as several separate data-entry tasks.

5. Target customer

The broad market is small and medium businesses, but the initial target is intentionally narrower.

Primary target: owners/managers of small physical businesses in Cameroon with frequent daily transactions, cash and/or Mobile Money activity, physical stock or consumables, and operational activity handled by employees.

Potential initial sectors include:

- Cyber / secretarial offices
- Mini-markets and grocery shops
- Cosmetics shops
- Phone and accessories shops
- General retail shops
- Other small businesses where stock and daily cash movements are significant

We should not initially treat every SME sector as identical. The product can remain general while the communication and workflows are adapted to the specific pain of each sector.

6. Ideal Customer Profile (ICP)

The ICP was defined around four dimensions: pain, business structure, operational complexity and ability/willingness to pay.

Ideal customer definition

An owner of a physical small business in Cameroon, typically with 2–10 employees, who is not always present during operations. The business generates frequent daily transactions and its revenue depends significantly on physical stock or consumables. The owner experiences or fears cash leakage, unexplained expenses, stock discrepancies or poor visibility of daily operations. The business has at least a smartphone with internet access, is comfortable with basic digital tools such as WhatsApp or Mobile Money, and has sufficient recurring revenue and perceived value to pay for a monthly or annual management solution.

Core criteria

Criterion	What it means
Real pain	The owner has experienced unexplained cash differences, stock shortages, undocumented expenses or poor visibility.
Owner not always present	Employees continue operating while the owner is away; this creates a need for remote control.
Multiple operators	Ideally 2–10 employees, or at least more than one person handling business operations.
Stock matters to revenue	Products/consumables move regularly and stock availability has a direct relationship with revenue.
Physical business	There is a real physical operating location.
Daily activity	There are enough transactions/movements for manual control to become difficult.
Digital readiness	At minimum, the business has a smartphone and internet access and uses basic digital services.
Ability to pay	The business has enough recurring revenue for the subscription to be affordable.
Willingness to pay	The owner sees sufficient financial value in preventing losses and improving control.

7. Important ICP nuance

“2+ employees” is a strong signal rather than an absolute rule. A one-employee business with very high transaction volume, significant stock and an absent owner could still be an excellent customer. Likewise, ability to pay is not the same as willingness to pay.

A strong customer also has something meaningful to lose: cash discrepancies or stock leakage are financially significant enough that paying for better control makes economic sense.

8. Existing software research

We studied three non-Excel products as benchmarks because they represent different approaches to the same territory:

Odoo — A mature, broad ERP reference connecting sales/POS, inventory, purchasing, accounting and many other business functions. It demonstrates the value of integrating business events across modules, but its breadth and configuration can be much greater than what a small business needs.

KiboERP — An African/SME-oriented benchmark combining POS, stock, purchases, payments, accounting, customers and business management. It is useful for studying an integrated SME workflow.

ShopTrack — The closest benchmark to our specific hypothesis because it explicitly targets small businesses in Cameroon/Africa and combines sales, stock, expenses, staff, reports, alerts and offline operation. It also emphasizes staff activity/audit visibility and owner control.

9. Lessons from the research

- The strongest architecture is event-based: one sale should update sales, money and stock automatically.
- Small-business employees should not have to enter the same information in several places.
- Offline operation is important for the Cameroon context and is part of our MVP direction.
- Owner and employee experiences should be different: employees need fast operational entry; owners need visibility and control.
- Auditability matters: important actions should be associated with the responsible user and timestamp.
- The owner needs a concise daily view rather than an overwhelming ERP dashboard.
- A daily reconciliation mechanism directly addresses the original pain and may become a signature feature.
- We should not build a smaller copy of Odoo or ShopTrack. Existing products already cover the general sales/stock/expense territory, so our differentiation must come from simplicity, workflow, control and fit with our ICP.

10. MVP — agreed functional direction

The MVP should contain the smallest set of capabilities that can solve the core daily-control problem convincingly.

MVP capability	Purpose
1. Fast sales / transactions	Employee records a sale quickly: product/service, quantity and payment method. The system automatically updates the related business data.
2. Money IN / OUT	Record income, expenses, cash withdrawals and other money movements with amount, reason/category, user and timestamp.
3. Stock management	Products with quantity, purchase price, selling price and minimum stock. Support

	stock entries, exits and adjustments. Normal sales automatically reduce stock.
4. Employees & permissions	Owner creates employees and controls what they can do. Employees should not automatically see sensitive information such as purchase prices or owner-level reports.
5. Audit trail	Important actions should record who did what and when. Changes should be traceable rather than silently disappearing.
6. Owner dashboard	A concise daily view: sales, expenses, expected cash, actual cash, discrepancies, stock alerts, top products and employee activity.
7. End-of-day reconciliation	Compare expected cash with actual cash and expose differences. Provide a simple mechanism for recording/explaining discrepancies.
8. Offline operation	Core operations should continue when connectivity is unavailable and synchronize when the connection returns. Offline capability is explicitly part of the MVP direction.

11. Example of the intended workflow

Example: an employee sells 3 juices for 1,500 FCFA.

1. Employee records: Juice $\times$ 3 $\rightarrow$ Cash.
2. Sales increase by 1,500 FCFA.
3. Cash increases by 1,500 FCFA.
4. Juice stock decreases by 3.
5. The employee and timestamp are recorded.
6. The owner can see the transaction later without requiring the employee to enter the same event again.

12. End-of-day control — signature use case

At closing, the system calculates expected cash from recorded transactions and movements. The employee counts the actual cash. The system displays any difference and allows a reason to be attached.

Example:

- Recorded sales: 125,000 FCFA
- Recorded expenses: 25,000 FCFA
- Expected cash: 100,000 FCFA
- Actual cash: 94,000 FCFA

- Difference: -6,000 FCFA
- The difference is then classified/explained if possible.

13. What is deliberately NOT in the MVP

- Full accounting / complete SYSCOHADA bookkeeping
- Payroll and HR
- CRM as a major module
- E-commerce
- Manufacturing
- Complex procurement
- Advanced enterprise reporting
- Large numbers of secondary modules
- AI features

These can be considered later. The MVP must first prove that Korah can help an owner control daily money and stock movements.

14. Product positioning at this stage

Internal positioning: “Business Manager / daily business control system for small businesses.”

The product should answer one fundamental owner question:

“What happened in my business today, and does the money and stock I have match what should be there?”

15. Decisions intentionally postponed

- Final market segmentation and priority vertical.
- Pricing model.
- Marketing strategy.
- Communication/advertising plan.
- Acquisition channels.
- Final differentiation against ShopTrack and other competitors.
- Expansion beyond the MVP.

These will be addressed after the MVP is built and evaluated, as planned.

16. Next phase

The immediate phase is product construction: build the MVP around the validated problem, the ICP and the core daily workflow. After the MVP is built, the next discussion will focus on the market, positioning, communication plan and advertising strategy.